PRAYER SERIES AT TIFERET EYAL

Listen: Why Do We Cover Our Eyes for the Shema?

Prayer Series, Part 3

Series: Prayer Series (Tiferet Eyal, 2021-22) **Shiur:** Part 3 of the six-part Prayer Series, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom for Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 14 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

In the first two shiurim the Rabbi covered the theology of prayer (why pray if Hashem knows our needs), its history and origins, and then the Siddur from Modeh Ani to Yishtabach, including Baruch She'amar, Nishmat, Pesukei DeZimrah and the Korbanot. Tonight's focus is the next part of the service, after the Kaddish: **the Shema and the brachot before and after it.** Next week: the Amidah and the customs of its repetition.

Part 1: Barechu, the Call to Communal Prayer

The core of tefillah

As explained last week, the essential parts of prayer are three:

1. **The Amidah**
2. **The Shema with its blessings before and after**
3. **Birkot HaShachar**

In the times of the Talmud and the early Geonim, until about 1,300 or 1,400 years ago, that was the entire tefillah. Pesukei DeZimrah was added later. So **Barechu** marks the moment we begin "prayer proper."

The most communal part of the service

Pesukei DeZimrah can be said alone; there is no concept of minyan for it. But the Shema and its blessings are **a communal, led service**:

- **Until the time of the Rosh** (Rabbeinu Asher, around the thirteenth century), the common practice was for **the hazan alone to say the blessings of the Shema** while everyone listened and answered amen. The Rosh saw that these are long blessings and people were not concentrating, so he had everyone read together with the hazan.
- This is why **the Sephardi custom of the hazan saying every word aloud is the correct one** historically: for the Shema and its blessings, the hazan was saying it on everyone's behalf, to be *motzi* them.

- The **Kedushah** in the middle of the first blessing was, according to many, instituted only to be said in a congregation.

"The Amidah is the time when you're alone, by yourself with God. And the Shema and the blessings, the time you're together in the community."

So Barechu is the hazan's call: "I am now going to be leading us in this blessing, in this recognition of HaKadosh Baruch Hu as the source of all. Join me. At the very least, listen." **Barechu goes back to the Mishnah.**

Why there is no Barechu at Mincha

Barechu is said only at Shacharit and Arvit, the two services with the blessings of the Shema. Mincha is just an Amidah, a silent prayer. We pray it with a minyan, but there is no congregational prayer together, so there is no Barechu.

The same logic explains **Barechu at the Torah reading**. Originally, the person called up would read his own portion on behalf of the whole congregation. So he called out Barechu: pay attention, I am doing this on your behalf.

Barechu at the end of the service

Daniel asked about the Barechu at the end of the service, by Aleinu. This, the Rabbi explained, is a much later addition, brought in the Rishonim, **for people who came late** and missed Barechu. Since it is such an important call, it was added at the end so latecomers at least hear it on the way out. The same applies to Barechu at the end of Arvit.

- **Shabbat and Yom Tov:** the **Rivash** argued that if it is a compensation, it only makes sense on weekdays. On Shabbat and Yom Tov no one comes later than the Torah reading, where they will have heard Barechu. **The Shulchan Aruch rules in two places, in Hilchot Tefillah and in Hilchot Shabbat, that on Shabbat and Yom Tov we do not say Barechu at the end.** This is the minhag of the Spanish and Portuguese, and of the Ashkenazim too.
- **Oriental Sephardim** do say it again, based on the **Arizal**, for kabbalistic reasons.

Standing and bowing for Barechu

- **There is no need to stand or bow for Barechu.** This is clear in the poskim.
- Among Ashkenazim standing became the minhag. Among Sephardim it is not sourced. The Spanish and Portuguese do stand: "I've searched and searched for some kind of source for this. I haven't found any." If you are in such a congregation, of course you stand out of respect for the minhag.
- **Most Sephardi communities stay seated.** If you were already standing for Kaddish, you remain standing as usual.
- **Hacham Ben Zion Abba Shaul** goes further: one **should not** bow, because we bow only where the Hachamim instituted bowing, and they never did so at Barechu.

Part 2: The Structure of the Blessings

A bracha is something that begins or ends with *Baruch Atah*. Around the Shema there are **two blessings before and one after**:

Blessing	Opens	Theme
1	**יוצר אור ובורא חשך**	**Creation**
2	**אהבת עולם**	**Revelation**
Shema		The unity of Hashem
3	**אמת ויציב**	**Redemption**

Creation, revelation, redemption: "essentially the foundations of Judaism." The formation of the universe in Bereshit, the giving of the Torah in Shemot, and redemption, from Egypt in the past and the Mashiach in the future. The same pattern holds morning and evening.

All in the present tense

Notice that the blessings are in the **present tense**. "This drama of creation, revelation and redemption is an ongoing drama." It is not that Hashem created the world, revealed Himself and then left. "God creates, and God also reveals, on a constant and regular basis." The Hachamim say the words of the Torah should be new and fresh in our eyes every day, not something received 3,000 years ago at Sinai. And redemption speaks of the past, our daily redemption, and the future.

These blessings were formulated by the **Men of the Great Assembly**, about 2,300 years ago. Since originally the hazan said them on everyone's behalf, someone who finds it difficult to pray can still be *yotzeh* by listening to the hazan saying each word.

Part 3: The First Blessing: Creation

"Who creates everything"

> **יוצר אור ובורא חשך, עושה שלום ובורא את הכל**: Hashem forms light, creates darkness, makes peace and creates everything.

The Gemara already notices that this paraphrases a verse in **Yeshayahu** but changes it. The verse reads **עושה שלום ובורא רע**, "makes peace and **creates evil**." Why did the Hachamim change it?

The whole point of the Shema is **Yichud Hashem**: there is only one primal source and force for everything that exists. So you might expect the blessing to keep "creates evil." But to soften it, the Hachamim used a euphemism, **בורא את הכל**, "creates everything." The Gemara then asks: in that case, why not soften "darkness" too, and say **נוגה**, dimness? Because we must make clear that Hashem controls both day and night, and **there aren't two forces**.

"The Hachamim have taken a pasuk in Yeshayahu and basically sweetened it up... Instead of specifically mentioning evil right at the beginning of the day, it's more general, He creates everything. We still nonetheless say darkness, because we have to make it very clear that Hashem is the source of everything."

(To Jane: we certainly need to know that we can choose good or bad, but we don't need to begin the day by reminding ourselves that Hashem created evil.)

Against dualism

This opening, which is also the opening of the Arvit blessing, is directed against dualism: the temptation to see suffering and evil as a force independent of, and opposed to, Hashem. In Christianity there is God, all good, and Satan doing evil, a contest between them. "No. This verse in Yeshayahu, and also this part of the prayer, affirms our belief that all forces emanate from the one HaKadosh Baruch Hu."

The Rabbi quoted a prolific Jewish author of the last generation who said the greatest obstacle to faith is suffering in this world. Many of the questions people ask boil down to this: why is there so much evil? Why do bad things happen to me when I'm a good person? "There's no satisfactory answer which ticks all the boxes." That is exactly why we remind ourselves morning and evening that there is one force behind good and bad.

Why the best time is the transition

This, said the Rabbi, is why the ideal (*mitzvah min hamuvchar*) is to pray at **netz**, sunrise. The Gemara speaks very highly of it.

- **The Rambam** holds that saying Shema **after sunrise** is no longer the first-instance (*lechatchila*) fulfilment, only *bedi'avad*.
- **We hold** it is still first-rate within the first three hours, though it is better before sunrise.
- For **Arvit**, the Shulchan Aruch says to pray as early as possible in the evening.

Why? Because these are the moments when we **see the forces changing**: night fading and day arriving, day fading and night arriving. "Don't see this as two separate forces. Use this time of transition as a way to recognise HaKadosh Baruch Hu is involved behind it all." It is hard to live like that. We see powerful people, we see sin, and we take them as separate parts of reality, forgetting that there is a Creator in control and direction of the world.

Shabbat additions

On Shabbat the first blessing has two extra paragraphs, because there is more time, with the same emphasis on creation. It also has **אין כערכך**, the four-part declaration that there is none like Hashem: in this world, the next world, the resurrection and the days of Mashiach. Hashem is behind it all.

The spiritual creation and the Kedushah

Creation includes the spiritual realms, "all the drama happening in the upper hemispheres." So the second part of the first blessing describes the **angels**, who worship Hashem and are sent on missions. We repeat what they say:

קדוש קדוש קדוש ה׳ צבאות (the haftarah of Parashat Yitro) **Yeshayahu** comes from.

ברוך כבוד ה׳ ממקומו **Yechezkel** comes from.

Both prophets had mystical visions of Hashem with His heavenly hosts.

Can an individual say this Kedushah alone? The Shulchan Aruch brings two opinions:

Opinion	Reasoning
The Rosh: may be said alone	Unlike the Kedushah of the Amidah (*Nakdishach*), which is itself a prayer sanctifying Hashem, here we are only **retelling what the angels say**, *sipur devarim*
The Rambam: only with a minyan	It is a real Kedushah, a *davar shebikdushah*. "Just like no one would ever dream to do *Nakdishach* without a minyan"

The Shulchan Aruch rules that we must be concerned for the Rambam's view. So when praying alone, say it not as a prayer but **as if reading verses from the prophets**, which is always permitted.

One blessing, two parts

The paragraph that follows Kedushah is often treated as something new, but it is not. Kedushah creates a dramatic "full stop," but the text simply continues describing the angels' pleasant songs and praises. So:

1. **First part:** the **physical** creation, sun, stars and luminaries.
2. **Second part:** the **spiritual** creation, the angels, through Kedushah and what follows.
3. **Conclusion: ברוך אתה ה׳ יוצר המאורות**.

Part 4: The Second Blessing: Revelation

We move from the cosmic beauty of the universe and Hashem's broad relationship with it to **Hashem's revelation and intimacy with humanity, especially the Jewish people.** You taught our ancestors to fear and appreciate You; do the same for us. Teach us Your Torah, give us the ability to understand and contemplate it, enlighten our eyes in Your Torah.

"The first blessing is very non-personal. God is amazing, but it's nothing to do with us. The second blessing is intimate, it's personal. God, You taught our ancestors, now teach us, give us a connection with You, choose us as well."

It ends **הבוחר בעמו ישראל באהבה**, "who chooses His people Israel with love," the perfect lead-in to the Shema. In the Spanish and Portuguese tradition this line is sung very ornately. "Whoever composed the music for the Spanish and Portuguese was a person of a great soul... Every place where there's a special part of the music is something very lofty." This is the climax. The Rabbi recalled that in yeshiva people spent a long time on this blessing, since it is our connection with Hashem and with the Torah.

Gathering the tzitzit

There is a custom, mentioned later (not by the Rambam), to gather the four tzitziyot here, because we mention bringing us in peace **from the four corners of the earth**. Really one should take the tzitzit only at the third paragraph of the Shema, which speaks of them.

The problem: people search for their tzitzit and mumble the words. "Again, this is the theme which we've seen already in this series. When lots of things are added on, you take away from the main thing." The point of this blessing is connection and relationship, and the tzitzit should not distract from it.

Ahavat Olam or Ahavah Rabbah

Sephardim say **אהבת עולם אהבתנו**; Ashkenazim say **אהבה רבה אהבתנו**. Most differences in tefillah are just differences of custom, but this is one of the only ones that **goes back to a debate in the Gemara itself**.

Text	Meaning	Followed by
אהבת עולם	**Everlasting** love, "very affectionate and emotional"	The **Rambam** and the **Rif**, the Sephardi Rishonim, and our minhag
אהבה רבה	**Great** love	**Tosafot** and the Ashkenazi Rishonim

The question is how intense and deep Hashem's love is: everlasting, or "just" great.

Part 5: The Shema Itself

245 words and 248

The blessings so far are rabbinic, from the Men of the Great Assembly. **The Shema itself is a mitzvah from the Torah.** It contains **245 words**.

The **Zohar** (not the halachic sources or Rishonim) says: add three words to make **248**, the number of positive mitzvot and of our limbs, so that we accept the yoke of Heaven with all 248 limbs. **The Shulchan Aruch follows the Zohar here**, and the hazan repeats **ה׳ אלהיכם אמת** on behalf of the congregation.

"Hashem Elokeichem at the end of the Shema isn't part of the Shema. Get this clear."

- **Ashkenazim:** when praying alone, they say **אל מלך נאמן** before the Shema to make up the three words. The first to record this is the **Agur**, around the fourteenth century. Another reason given: the Gemara in Shabbat says **אמן** is an abbreviation of *El Melech Ne'eman*.
- **Sephardim** do not say it, because it would be an **interruption** (*hefsek*).

There is also a discussion about answering amen at this point. Sephardim hold one does not answer amen; Ashkenazim are more equivocal, which is why they recommend finishing together with the hazan.

What Shema means

שמע is more than hearing. In Hebrew, *atah shome'a?* means "do you understand?" The Rabbi cited the previous week's parashah: when the brothers blamed each other for selling Yosef, they **did not know that Yosef understood** (**כי שמע יוסף**), because he had positioned an interpreter. Of course he heard them; he was pretending not to understand. So *Shema* means to listen, understand, reflect and appreciate the unity of Hashem.

Why we cover our eyes

The custom goes back to the **Gemara**: Rabbi was in the middle of teaching when the time for Shema came, and he covered his eyes and said it. But why?

- **The Rambam:** simply **to concentrate**. He had students in front of him.

- **The Ramchal:** we don't need reminding twice a day that there is only one God. What we need reminding of is that **everything that happens in this world emanates from Hashem**, and that is hard. Covering our eyes says: "HaKadosh Baruch Hu, I can't see Your unity. If I look at this world I see discrepancy, light and darkness, good and bad. I can't see the Yichud Hashem, and that's why I'm covering my eyes. However, I believe in it."

Yaakov and Yosef

The Rabbi told "a beautiful" idea from the previous week's parashah. After 22 years, Yaakov and Yosef meet. Yosef falls on Yaakov's neck, but the Hachamim say Yaakov did not fall on Yosef's, because **Yaakov was saying Kriat Shema**. Why only Yaakov? If it was the time for Shema, Yosef should have said it too.

The answer: **Yosef had experienced the Yichud Hashem.** He had been sold, sent down to Egypt, and saw how it all led to him providing for the whole world. For him it wasn't belief; he had lived Shema Yisrael for 22 years. Yaakov had lived only with **belief**: "Where has my son Yosef gone? I believe everything comes from Hashem. I can't see it." Now, reunited with his son, he finally saw it. That was the moment to say *Shema Yisrael, Hashem Echad*.

Baruch Shem silently

is said quietly. According to the Ramchal, this was the secret **ברוך שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד** Yaakov revealed to his sons before he died: the revelation of Hashem's glory and kingship in the time of Mashiach. **We believe it but don't yet see it**, so we say it quietly. On **Yom Kippur**, when we are separated from our physical desires and are "all good," without the balance of good and .bad, we say it **aloud**

Saying the Shema aloud together

Rabbi David Abudarham, the Spanish commentator on the prayer book (fourteenth or fifteenth century), records the minhag that **the whole community says the first verse aloud together**, as if all testifying for one another. In the Torah the **ע** of *Shema* and the **ד** of *Echad* are written large, spelling **עד**, a witness. The Rabbi had only seen this minhag kept among the **Spanish and Portuguese**, where everyone joins the hazan aloud with a special tune. As Jane noted, this is also why we say Shema before death: to recognise that everything comes from Hashem.

The paragraphs of the Shema

- The first two paragraphs are the Torah mitzvah of Shema: the **acceptance of the yoke of Heaven**, *kabbalat ol malchut shamayim*, and the **acceptance of the yoke of the mitzvot**.
- The third paragraph, **tzitzit**, was added because there is a mitzvah to **remember the Exodus every day**. Many verses could do that, but this one has a double advantage: it remembers Egypt, and tzitzit are a reminder of the mitzvot we have just accepted.

Part 6: The Third Blessing: Redemption

The final blessing begins **ויציב ונכון וקים וישר ונאמן**: **fifteen adjectives**, all meaning essentially "true." Why fifteen?

Source	Reason
Abudarham (Flora's suggestion)	The **15 steps** in the Temple and the 15 *Shir HaMa'alot* psalms sung on them
The Zohar, quoted by the **Shulchan Aruch**	Each word has the *vav* (6): 15 × 6 = **90**. Hashem's four-letter name is 26, plus its 4 letters, is **30**; three times for the **three paragraphs** of the Shema = 90

"It's quite rare for the Shulchan Aruch to incorporate not just the Zohar, but the reasons of the Zohar."

The word **אמת** appears **six** times. The Abudarham explains: for the three paragraphs of the Shema and the three blessings around it. Everything we have said is true. The blessing speaks of the redemption from Egypt and at the Red Sea, and ends **גאל ישראל**: He redeemed us, and He will redeem us.

Summary

1. **The core of tefillah** is the Amidah, the Shema with its blessings, and Birkot HaShachar. **Barechu** (from the Mishnah) opens the **communal** part. Until the Rosh, the hazan said these blessings for everyone, which is why the Sephardi hazan reading every word aloud is historically correct.
2. **No Barechu at Mincha**, which has no Shema. **Barechu at the end** is a late compensation for latecomers; per the **Rivash** and **Shulchan Aruch**, not said on Shabbat and Yom Tov (Spanish and Portuguese, Ashkenazim), though Oriental Sephardim say it following the Arizal. **No need to stand**; Hacham Ben Zion Abba Shaul says not to bow.
3. **Creation, revelation, redemption**, all in the **present tense**.
4. **Creation:** "creates everything" softens Yeshayahu's "creates evil," but "darkness" stays to reject **dualism**. Pray at the transitions of **sunrise and nightfall**. Kedushah alone: the Rosh permits, the Rambam requires a minyan; the Shulchan Aruch says to say it as reading verses.
5. **Revelation:** personal and intimate, climaxing in "who chooses His people Israel with love." Don't let gathering tzitzit distract. **Ahavat Olam** (Sephardim, Rambam, Rif) vs **Ahavah Rabbah** (Ashkenazim, Tosafot), a debate from the Gemara.
6. **Shema:** 245 words; *Hashem Elokeichem Emet* makes 248 (Zohar, Shulchan Aruch). Ashkenazim say *El Melech Ne'eman* alone; Sephardim consider it a *hefsek*. **Shema** means understand. We **cover our eyes** to concentrate (Rambam) or because we cannot yet see Hashem's unity (Ramchal), like Yaakov saying Shema on meeting Yosef. **Baruch Shem** is quiet, except on Yom Kippur.
7. **Redemption:** fifteen words of truth (Abudarham: the Temple steps; Zohar and Shulchan Aruch: 90, three times Hashem's name) and six times *emet*.

Coming Up

Next week, the final shiur of 2021: the depth of the **Amidah**, and the customs of its **repetition**.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/2r_6e3cjB0Q · More shiurim: rabbikada.com